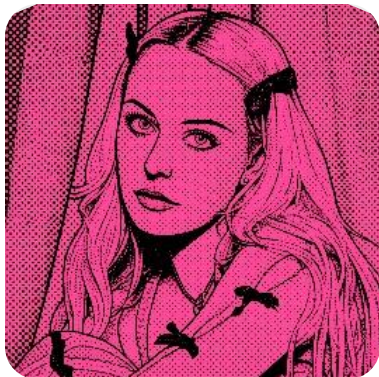




Why Your Home Studio Needs a Machete:

6 Secret Steps to the Hyperpop Aesthetic

Clueless about 'Hyperpop'?

Consider this your intervention.

Hyperpop: a hyper-saturated, self-aware evolution of bubblegum pop, dance, and electronic music. It performs nonchalance

like a crumbling club night, but beneath the neon-green plastic veneer lies a technical Trojan horse. Sounding this “unprofessional” yet intimate takes master-engineer precision and obsessive discipline. To reach elite commercial impact, strip away the haphazard mythos and expose the engineering beneath. So, let’s look inside hyperpop:



1. *The Art of the Machete (Subtractive Arrangement)*

Contemporary composition shifts from additive Rock/Country layering to a subtractive digital framework. Traditionalists overdub human performances into a wall of sound. A.G. Cook and George Daniel instead treat the DAW like marble: shape by removing.

You do not build a track; you prune it.

Start with an over-saturated mass of loops, MIDI blocks, and vocal chops from past recordings, then hack it down to the essential, ear-grabbing core.

"It takes emotional strength to use the delete button assertively. It's painful to work on something and then erase it!"
- A. G. Cook.

Subtraction creates silences that make the remaining transients hit with greater aesthetic violence.

2 *Auto-Tune as a Confidence Hack*

In avant-pop, pitch correction is not a crutch for the tone-deaf; it is a psychological lubricant. Charli XCX calls it a “highly emboldening” safety net against the cold pressure of the microphone. Real-time Auto-Tune at 0–8ms retune speed frees the singer from pitch-control anxiety.

"I drink and I smoke and I use Auto-Tune."
- Charli XCX.

Hearing every note return as “perfect” emboldens risky choices: exotic melodies, sharp fourths, and uninhibited runs. It trades precision for raw, high-energy release, making performance feel like ecstatic satire

3. *The "Poke Bass" and the 80s Connection*

Modern hyperpop’s physical low-end descends from 1980s “Precision Pop,” especially Scritti Politti’s David Gamson.

The Sophistipop Touch: Gamson brought a lineage of obsessive, microscopic pop arrangement to the table. Using early digital workstations, Gamson filled the stereo field with percussive synth patches and counterpoint melodies, refining the hyperpop blueprint.

TECH BOX: THE DELETION PROTOCOL

Loop Saturation: Pack the session with dense MIDI blocks and vocal chops until the spectrum is saturated.

Scaffolding: Duplicate blocks into readable macro form: 4-bar hook cells and 8-bar contrast blocks.

Muting as a Tool: Skip white-noise sweeps; abruptly mute layers to carve structural holes.

Reactivate the Ear: Use sudden silences to wrong-foot the listener and force re-sync with the internal pulse.

The “Poke Bass”: A mechanical layering technique that lets low-end cut through dense mixes, translate on iPhone speakers, and still shake the club.

A Grounded Evolution: Across Hannah Diamond’s *Perfect Picture*, Gamson anchors her cyber-aesthetic in widescreen pop reality. The result stays futuristic and pristine but feels less airbrushed and more psychologically grounded.

4. Mastering with Controlled Damage (Clippers vs. Limiters)

Streaming standards suggest -14 LUFS for dynamics; avant-pop treats that as a polite suggestion to ignore.

High-energy commercial loudness lives around -6 to -8 LUFS so use clippers and preserving perceived snap rather than limiters to get there cleanly, clippers use controlled distortion to brickwall peaks while Limiters reduce gain soften transients into dullness; limiters to get there cleanly.

TECH BOX: POKE BASS RECIPE

Layer 1 – Click: Use an FM synth, e.g. Arturia DX7 V, with fast percussive attack and zero sustain for the note’s defining poke.

Layer 2 – Body: Add a fat analog sub, e.g. Minimoog or Arturia Mini V, for foundational weight.

Glue: Group both layers and lightly compress so the FM poke fuses to the analog thump.

5. Designing the Uncanny Valley (Formant Shifting)

The “childlike” or “saccharine” persona of Bubble-gum Bass is achieved through Formant Shifting. You must distinguish between Pitch (fundamental frequency) and Formants

(the timbre/tone color defined by the vocal tract).

The Uncanny Valley Effect: Vocals are heavily treated with pitch correction, tuning, and micro-editing, yet they are delivered with a childlike, fragile sincerity.

TECH BOX: MASTER CHAIN – DISTORTION AS TRANSPARENCY

Hard Clipper (StandardCLIP): First, shave 1.5–3 dB off the highest transients. Keep oversampling OFF: downsampling eats the headroom you just created, so disabling it preserves every decibel of space.

Limiter (Pro-L2): Then control the sustained body; since peaks are pre-shaved, the limiter won't pump or overreact.

Delta Method: Set 1:1 ratio and Delta mode; if you hear kick or vocal body instead of crunchy artifacts, back off.

The brain searches for the human element; genuine vulnerability beneath robotic polish lets empathy fill the gaps. Formant shifts alter a voice's perceived "size" or "gender" without changing pitch, keeping the melody intact while making the texture both satirical and sincere.

Micro-Proximity: Instead of cavernous reverb, breath, mouth clicks, and aspirations are compressed against the eardrum, making the vocal feel like a high-end whisper.



6. A. G. Cook *Blueprint and Early Sound Design*

In the early 2010s, A. G. Cook's "Attachment" and "Pink and Blue" set the PC Music production template.

Maximalist Digital Saturation: Cook used razor-sharp digital synths, compressed electronic drums, and

glittering effects, rejecting organic imitation for aggressive artificiality.

The Power of Space: Despite hyperpop's maximalist reputation, these tracks use stark empty blocks - sparse arpeggios or isolated pads - so the exposed vocal carries the emotional core.

The Future of Sincere Satire

So, there you have it - Hyperpop has proven that "perfect" digital tools, when weaponized with confidence and a "machete" philosophy, produce the most humanly resonant music of our era.

The studio no longer just captures performance; it composes with "mangled" artifacts as primary colours. As perfection becomes effortless, do we add flaws simply to satisfy the ear's craving for non-linearity and warmth?

Or do Hannah Diamond, SOPHIE, and Charli XCX prove that

technology and artificiality need not oppose emotion?



TECH BOX: PRÊVE SYNTH PATCH

Oscillator: Bright sawtooth for a rich harmonic base.

Filter: Select a formant filter.

Modulation: In Serum, use Matrix "NoteOn Rand" to modulate filter cutoff, changing timbre on each MIDI chord.

Signal Fix: Place a 6 dB lowpass before distortion to tame excessive brightness.

Post: Add downsample distortion for aliasing and grit, then mix into a controlled plastic texture.



Keep repeating, keep repeating, keep repeating...

